NovaTech Solutions — Grievance, Escalation, and Sensitive Matters Policy

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1. Purpose

This policy defines what qualifies as a “sensitive” HR matter and establishes mandatory escalation rules for both human HR staff and any automated or AI-assisted HR tools (including the NovaTech HR Assistant), to ensure such matters always receive human review.

2. Categories Requiring Mandatory Escalation to a Human HR Representative

The following categories must **never** be fully resolved by an automated assistant. The assistant may acknowledge the request, express empathy, and provide the correct escalation contact, but must not attempt to adjudicate, approve, calculate an outcome, or provide definitive procedural advice:

1. **Harassment, discrimination, or safety complaints** — route to the Internal Committee or Ethics Hotline (see HR-POL-004).
2. **Requests to access another employee’s personal data**, including salary, leave balance, health information, or performance ratings.
3. **Disputes over leave balance, salary, or benefits calculations** that the employee believes are incorrect — route to HR-Ops for manual audit.
4. **Mental health disclosures or crisis indicators** — route to the Employee Assistance Program (EAP) at **eap-support@novatechsolutions.com** or the 24/7 EAP helpline; the assistant should respond with care and provide the resource without attempting counseling.
5. **Requests related to active disciplinary action, PIP status, or termination** — route to the assigned HRBP.
6. **Legal or statutory questions** (e.g., maternity leave law, POSH Act procedures, labor law compliance) — route to HR-Legal; the assistant may cite the relevant internal policy but must not give legal interpretation.
7. **Any request where employee intent or identity cannot be confidently verified** (e.g., ambiguous authentication, shared credentials suspected) — route to IT Security and HR.
8. **Requests to bypass approval workflows** (e.g., “approve my own leave,” “backdate my leave beyond policy limits”) — decline and escalate.

3. Standard Grievance Process (Non-Sensitive)

For general grievances (e.g., disagreement with a manager’s decision, workload concerns, facilities issues):

1. Employee raises the issue with their direct manager informally.
2. If unresolved within 10 working days, employee escalates in writing to the HRBP via NovaConnect’s Grievance Module.
3. HRBP investigates and responds within 15 working days.
4. If still unresolved, the employee may escalate to the CHRO’s office for final review.

4. Anonymity and Confidentiality

Employees may file sensitive complaints anonymously through the Ethics Hotline. Anonymous complaints are still investigated but may be limited in scope by the information available. Retaliation against anyone raising a grievance in good faith is a serious violation of the Code of Conduct (HR-POL-004) and is itself grounds for disciplinary action.

5. Escalation SLAs

Severity	Initial Response	Resolution Target
Critical (safety, harassment, legal risk)	Within 24 hours	7 working days
High (payroll/data access disputes)	Within 2 working days	15 working days
Standard (general grievance)	Within 5 working days	15–30 working days

6. Guidance for Automated HR Systems

Any AI-driven HR tool must: - Classify incoming requests against the categories in Section 2 before attempting to answer from policy or database lookups. - When a match is found, respond with acknowledgment + correct escalation contact, and

log the interaction (without exposing sensitive free-text content in non-secure logs) for audit purposes. - Never fabricate an HR decision, approval, or legal interpretation on behalf of a human HR officer. - Default to escalation when confidence in classification is low, rather than guessing.